



UNODC

STUDY GUIDE



Agenda Item: Combating the Online Trafficking of Drugs on The Dark Web

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1. Letter From Secretary General

It is my great pleasure to welcome you to the 2026 session of TEKMUN. On behalf of the Secretariat and the Organization Team, we are very excited to host you for an amazing experience of diplomacy, negotiation, and teamwork.

In today's fast-changing world, we need critical thinking and cooperation more than ever. At TEKMUN'26, we believe that young people are not just future leaders, but today's problem solvers, we aim to provide a platform where different views come together to create new solutions.

Our team has carefully prepared a wide range of committees. Whether this is your first time as a delegate or you are highly experienced, you will find a great place to express your ideas. Throughout the conference, we expect to see active debates, strong teamwork, and, above all, mutual respect. We're not preparing just any conference, we're bringing a new vision to Tekirdag's MUN Culture.

I encourage you to take this opportunity with an open mind. Challenge yourselves, listen to others, and try to find a common ground. Let's work together to make TEKMUN'26 a highly successful and memorable conference.

I look forward to meeting you all very soon.

Sincerely,

Mehmet Emre Battal

2. Letter From Head of Academy

Dear Delegates, Chairboards, Observers, and Esteemed Participants,
It's my utmost pleasure to welcome you all to TEKMUN '26. I'm Yiğit Yılmaz, and I am currently studying at Tekirdağ Anatolian High School as a 12th grader and I have the honour of serving as Head of Academy through this conference. First of all, I would like to thank our Secretary General and Director General for giving me this opportunity.

While we tackle similar challenges, the contexts may differ across borders. Major problems are evident not only in newspapers but also on social media, which also emphasises the need for awareness and action. Let us draw inspiration from influential figures like Mahatma Gandhi, Martin Luther King Jr., and Mustafa Kemal Atatürk and many more. Their legacies remind us of the impact, but can't be mentioned in just 1 page. We can achieve this when we unite to address global challenges. Combating the Online Trafficking of Drugs on The Dark Web. Over the years, there have been many problems that everyone needs to be aware of, including the Combating the Online Trafficking of Drugs and also these includes at UN aims for 17 goals, and two of them are no peace, justice and strong institutions and good health and well-being, which is why everyone deserves to live equally in the world.

As the Head of Academy of this conference, We created this Study Guide to gain a clearer understanding of the topic before the conference. If you have any questions about the committee or the procedures, please feel free to reach out to me or any other chair members.

Sincerely,
Yiğit Yılmaz

3. Letter From Under Secretary General of UNODC

Esteemed delegates, it is an honor to welcome all of you to TEKMUN'26. We hope we can provide every single one of you with the best possible committee experience that you can get. During these four days you will engage in meaningful debate, discuss important topics and most importantly improve upon yourselves. There might be moments where you are feeling down or unimportant but we advise all of you to speak up whenever you feel like you have something to bring to the table. We look forward to meeting each and every single one of you at the conference.

In today's world crime is in every corner of the world. They are communicating with each other in various ways in order to plan acts that only benefit themselves and harm others. There are ways that they even can get away with the crimes they have committed. Each and every single act of crime or terrorism left unchecked creates a great danger for our society as a whole. The popularization of drugs to the general public creates a great danger as taking drugs is a dangerous activity that not only causes people to lose their lives but at times it even causes people to lose touch with reality. Every way that you can get ahead of drug trafficking and crime is another life saved so your actions are pivotal to save innocent lives. You need to find their ways of thinking, how they get away with what they do, and find ways to stop them without harming the public's privacy or comfort.

Hopefully this committee will be your first step in taking action against unfairness, injustice and corruption. We hope you leave this conference with a sense of meaningful achievement. May you make wise decisions and reach greatness.

Yours sincerely,

Poyraz Efe Deniz

Under Secretary General

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4. Introduction to The Committee

a. What is UNODC?

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) is the lead office to assist member states in their fight against illicit substance trafficking, transnational organised crime and acts of planned terrorism. UNODC was established in 1997 when the United Nations Drug Control Programme and the Centre for International Crime Prevention were merged. The headquarters of the establishment is located in Vienna, Austria. UNODC has approximately 500 staff members and it operates 20 field offices. As a result, UNODC plays an important role in helping countries address drug trafficking through international cooperation and shared strategies. Its work is especially relevant to emerging forms of drug trafficking that use digital platforms and modern technologies.

UNODC works to educate people throughout the world about the dangers of drug abuse and to strengthen international action against illicit drug production and trafficking and drug-related crime. To achieve those aims, UNODC has launched a range of initiatives, including alternatives in the area of illicit drug crop cultivation, monitoring of illicit crops and the implementation of projects against money laundering. These efforts demonstrate that combating drug trafficking requires more than simply stopping the physical movement of drugs. Financial investigations, prevention programs and international information sharing can also contribute to reducing the activities of criminal networks.

UNODC also works to improve crime prevention and assist with criminal justice reform in order to strengthen the rule of law, promote stable and viable criminal justice systems and combat the growing threats of transnational organized crime and corruption. In 2002, the General Assembly approved an expanded program of

activities for the Terrorism Prevention Branch of UNODC. The activities focus on providing assistance to States, on request, in ratifying and implementing the eighteen universal legal instruments against terrorism.

These responsibilities make cooperation between member states an essential part of UNODC's work. In the context of dark web drug trafficking, stronger legal systems and coordinated international action can help countries respond to crimes that extend beyond their national borders.

b. Key Terms and Basic Explanations

Surface web: Parts of the World Wide Web that are indexed by standard search engines. Contains 4 percent of the World Wide Web and can be accessed by everyone with internet access.

Deep Web: Parts of the World Wide Web whose contents are not indexed by standard search engines. Contains 96 percent of the World Wide Web and its contents include password protected mail accounts, free-for-service (FFS) services and unindexed sites.

Dark Web: Part of the World Wide Web that can only be accessed with special routers which gives users random IP addresses in order to hide their identities to keep them anonymous.

Cryptocurrencies: Any form of currency that exists digitally or virtually and uses cryptography to secure transactions. Cryptocurrencies don't have a central issuing or regulating authority, instead using a decentralized system to record transactions and issue new units.

Drug mules: Drug mules are essentially couriers that transfer illicit drugs both internationally and locally.

Privacy Coins: Cryptocurrencies designed to provide users with a higher level of privacy by making transactions more difficult to trace or link to a specific person.

Blockchain: A digital system that records transactions in a secure and organized way. Information is stored in connected blocks, making it difficult to change previous records without being detected.

Encryption: The process of converting information into a coded form so that only authorized people can access and understand it.

Anonymity: The state of having your identity hidden or unknown, making it difficult for others to determine who you are.

Pseudonym: A name or identity used by someone instead of their real name, often to prevent their real identity from being revealed.

Peer to Peer Network: A network where computers or users communicate and share information directly with each other instead of relying on a central server.

Cybercrime: Criminal activity that involves computers, digital devices or the internet, such as fraud, hacking, identity theft or illegal online transactions.

Encrypted Messaging Applications: Applications that use encryption to protect messages from being accessed by unauthorized people while they are being sent or stored.

Cross Border Crime: Criminal activity that involves more than one country, either because the people involved, the victims, the servers or other parts of the crime are located in different countries.

Jurisdiction: The legal authority of a country or organization to make and enforce laws and deal with specific crimes or legal matters.

5. Introduction to Agenda Item

a. Overview of Online Drug Trafficking on the Dark Web:

The emergence of the Dark Web has significantly affected the illicit drug trafficking market by providing criminals a platform to communicate anonymously and privately. The main reason that the dark web drug trade is such a threat is that unlike traditional ways that the criminals use they cannot be tracked as they leave almost no trace behind because the network is quite literally the most private part of the whole world wide web. Users typically access these networks through special specifically designed software, such as Tor (The Onion Router) which hides their identities and locations by routing internet traffic through multiple encrypted layers. Even though the dark web only takes up a small percentage of the whole world wide web, as it is less than one percent of it, it still is quite dangerous and users who access it face great threats such as their data getting stolen or being subjected to a number of illegal activities that include the trafficking of drugs, illegal pornography or cases of homicide.

Online drug trafficking on the dark web began to gain traction in the early 2010s with the rise of anonymous drug markets. These markets function similarly to the average legal online commerce services with the main diversion from them being the exploitation of anonymity services. These markets allow vendors to advertise, transfer and profit off of illicit drugs quite easily. The proliferation of these markets harm both the global economy by laundering large amounts of money and average citizens as it creates a platform for them to reach customers remotely.

The most significant and well known drug market on the dark web is the silk road. Silk road was established by Ross Ulbricht in February 2011 and was eventually shut down by law enforcement in 2013. Even though its short lifetime the silk road has managed to deal major harm to the global economy. Some estimates suggest that Silk Road generated up to \$1.2 billion in sales and \$80 million in commissions, though more conservative estimates are \$183 million in sales and \$13 million in commissions. The transactions on this market were mostly done with the assist of cryptocurrencies, more specifically bitcoin. The silk road serves as a reminder of the damage that can be caused by criminals on a network where they cannot be tracked and stopped.

One of the primary factors that popularized the online drug market is the use of cryptocurrencies. Digital currencies such as bitcoin are frequently used on these types of transactions with the benefits of having multiple degrees of privacy to them. Most of these transactions are quite hard to track because blockchain based currencies encrypt and spread the transaction data into multiple servers.

Although public perception often associates the dark web with criminal acts, this view does not fully reflect the full scope of it. The dark web has legitimate uses such as providing users secure communication and a truly private browsing experience. Some individuals occupations even depend on the privacy of the dark web such as journalists, activists, law enforcement and whistleblowers using the privacy of the dark web for various reasons. There are multiple reasons that average people engage with it with clearly innocent reasons so shutting the whole thing down is not an option. Shutting down tor, and along with it the dark web, has colossal odds of

backfiring as the criminal activities might migrate elsewhere or groups of people might be displeased as they might see this act as a way of stealing their privacy.

6. Causes and Driving Factors of the Dark Web Drug Trade

a. Anonymity

One of the primary reasons the dark web drug market has been on the rise is the anonymity it brings. Users often tend to use pseudonyms in order to hide their identities, avoid legal or social consequences or act as someone who they are not. Tor assigns randomized IP addresses to every user, this makes so that vendors and customers of these markets have a lower chance of getting caught. Individuals who would normally not get involved with this type of illicit acts fall to the ways of crime because they feel not responsible for their actions while they don't have their real identity online and so the anonymity aspect of the dark web becomes the very reason a group of people enter the world of crime. This anonymity creates a significant challenge for law enforcement agencies trying to identify individuals involved in illegal activities. It also makes it harder to connect online identities with real world individuals and investigate criminal networks. Therefore, developing effective investigative methods while respecting legitimate privacy remains an important challenge.

b. Worldwide Reach

The global accessibility of the internet has allowed vendors and drug traffickers to meet and make sales overseas. Thanks to the reach of the dark web anyone trying to sell drugs online can meet potential clients from other regions, countries and even continents. Not being limited to any given local area helps these criminals make significantly more profit. These kinds of international drug trafficking is also a major problem for law enforcement as local law enforcements left useless and international offices of law enforcement have to follow multiple nations' jurisdictions and legal systems.

Transportation of the illicit drugs can be done in various ways with each of them having their pros and cons to the distributors. The first way is the usage of drug mules. A mule essentially is a courier, and serves the purpose of delivering the illicit drugs. Mules do not have to be the smugglers friend or ally and their relationship with the smuggler is in most cases can be observed to have some correlation with the type of drug they are delivering. Easy to replace drugs such as fentanyl do not need highly trustable mules but hard to replace expensive and valuable drugs such as heroin and cocaine usually are carried by mules that are at least on some level trusted by the distributor. The second and the more common way of transporting the drugs are postal services. The drugs are usually pretty well hidden within the contents of the sent package so often they are left unseen. Despite the advantages of having mules, postal systems remain the most popular way of transporting illicit drugs across nations.

c. Low Physical Risk

Traditional methods of trafficking drugs contain a lot of risks including getting caught by law enforcement or vendors getting identities exposed, selling illegal drugs on the dark web however mostly eliminates those risks by exterminating the need of a physical meet up so often times the low physical risks are one of the biggest contributing factors why vendors tend to migrate their businesses to the web. This reduced physical interaction can make traditional law enforcement methods less effective and create additional challenges for investigators. As a result, authorities need to adapt their investigative approaches to address the digital nature of these transactions.

International cooperation and digital investigations can play an important role in identifying and disrupting such criminal networks.

d. Trends and The Internet Culture

Even though it has been relevant ever since its establishment in the early 2000s dark web as a trend has begun to surge into its major popularity around mid 2010s once smartphones and smart devices became household items. Once smart devices were the standard and the internet became accessible to everyone, people started producing content around the dark web as it seemed like a mysterious and undocumented part of the internet. This proliferation of content centered around the dark web has enabled the general public to be aware of its existence and get curious about the topic so many people have ventured into the dark web and eventually that enables them to either stumble up with or intentionally find the markets. This development of marketing the dark web as something cool and mysterious have caused groups of people to learn about and eventually keep the market going. Using drugs being marketed and labeled as cool is largely a problem around teens and young adults however the combination of both drugs and dark web being labeled as cool is one of the primary reasons that many young people become customers of the markets.

7. Challenges Faced While Combatting Against the Dark Web Drug Trade

a. Jurisdictional Complications and Cross Border Legal Enforcement

A single dark web transaction can include a vendor , a buyer and a server all in different countries. National law enforcement possess power within their own borders so any action taken against a crime that involves multiple parts located in different nations requires cross border cooperation which complicates things further. This makes cooperation between national law enforcement agencies essential in combating online drug trafficking. Countries may need to

develop faster and more effective mechanisms for sharing information and coordinating investigations.

Cross nation agreements on the conditions and permissions on most scenarios takes some time to reach a conclusion. By the time a conclusive agreement is reached the digital evidence can be discarded or the suspects might have moved to another platform before any sort of meaningful action can be taken. Criminals on the internet move fast so any time wasted means a potential for them to get away with it. Establishing clearer international procedures could reduce delays and allow authorities to respond more effectively. Strengthening cooperation while respecting national laws and jurisdiction could make cross-border investigations more efficient.

b. Adaptability of The Markets

One of the most frustrating challenges that law enforcement has to go through is the fact that taking down a big marketplace on the dark web has serious consequences. Once a large market is busted the customers and the vendors immediately start looking for and creating alternatives which in turn results in more marketplaces being created and the users spreading to different places. This has happened multiple times in the recorded history of the dark web with the most significant one being the takedown operation on the silk road which brought more eyes to the dark web as the takedown was talked about globally which in turn created more customers and vendors. This demonstrates that shutting down a single platform may not be enough to permanently reduce illegal activity. Law enforcement agencies must also consider how criminal networks reorganize themselves after major operations.

After silk road the same developers created Silk Road 2.0 which was also busted rather quickly. The biggest effect of the takedowns was the emergence of many new markets with the goal of supplying the demand for a new major market for illicit drugs such as BMR (Black Market Reloaded). BMR as a matter of fact got so popular that the reasoning behind its eventual

shutdown was that the servers could not handle the amount of people using it. The same pattern of several alternative markets getting created can also be seen with the example of the shutdown of Hydra Market in 2022 and Archetyp Market in 2025. This pattern shows that an immediate shutdown of big markets result in both the vendors and the buyers migrating to different platforms which complicates things as now law enforcement has more than one place to investigate and the creation of more platforms means that drugs on the dark web get more accessible as now it can be bought from multiple sources. A long term strategy should therefore focus not only on removing individual marketplaces but also on disrupting the networks that support them. International cooperation and continuous monitoring could help authorities respond more effectively when new platforms emerge.

c. Privacy and Security

The topic of how far governments are willing to go in order to create a safe environment on the internet is a heavily debated topic especially in recent times with the surge in popularity of the dark web. Weakening encryption and anonymization tools in order to slow down criminals effects the people who are truly using it for innocent purposes such as journalism and activism. Governments must therefore consider whether new security measures could unintentionally harm legitimate users. Finding a balance between effective law enforcement and the protection of privacy remains an important challenge for the international community.

Certain groups of people need those tools to stay safe on the internet as they are often attacked for various reasons by people with malicious intentions. On the other hand it can be argued that the existence of these powerful tools creates a safe space for drug trades to take place. These types of tools are in a way a double edged sword. Both malicious and innocent people use it in their own ways so discarding it entirely is not an option but keeping it so easy to reach also creates danger. Therefore, governments should focus on targeted measures that prevent criminal activity without unnecessarily limiting legitimate users. International cooperation can also help establish common standards for balancing online security, privacy, and law enforcement needs.

8. The Role of Cryptocurrencies and Other Anonymous Networks

a. Privacy Coins

Normal blockchain based cryptocurrencies that have been used for many years make it a challenge to track exchanges but the recent progress done in the field of blockchain forensics make it possible to find and track down the criminals. So in response there has been a shift to what is known commonly as privacy coins. These coins most often aim to blend in the transactions with other users by using several different techniques.

The most popular example of these privacy coins is called Monero and it actually has been around for quite some time by now. The coin was first released to the public on April 18 2014 with the goal of being a private decentralized cryptocurrency to keep ones finances confidential and secure. On paper it has achieved its goal as it is used for personal reasons but the excessive privacy features it provides make it a criminal go to. Once again banning them entirely or even weakening the security measures deeply effects the people who are just using it to be more private but keeping them as they are also benefits the individuals who are using it maliciously.

b. Decentralized Markets

As the drug trade evolved the marketplaces realized keeping their operation on a single server was too risky as they could be taken down in just a single strike so they adapted to the given situation as they always do by making their marketplaces run on different servers and computers all at once. By creating these decentralized markets they have achieved more power as they became harder to both track down and get shut down by investigators and law enforcements.

2025 was the rise of this trend as sites such as Hydra and HyperBay which had admin management were taken down because of the vulnerabilities of centralized networks. These decentralized markets are based on encrypted peer to peer (P2P) systems so they are significantly

less likely to get caught by enforcers and even though there are many departments all over the globe who are specialized in this exact type of crime this new development on the foundation of the marketplaces essentially makes them untraceable as these departments were mostly created before this development and therefore they are not able to deal with this threat in a proper way.

c. Encrypted Messaging Apps

Encrypted messaging apps such as telegram offer true private chats with people but as it can be seen with many other encryption and anonymity services they can and are being actively used by criminal groups and organizations. The privacy they provide are actually being used with legitimate purpose but is often misused with malicious goals. Encrypted messaging apps therefore unintentionally create a safe haven for criminals to band together and plan criminal acts. This creates another challenge for law enforcement, as authorities must distinguish between legitimate private communication and criminal activity. Governments should therefore seek solutions that address the misuse of these platforms without unnecessarily weakening privacy protections for ordinary users. International cooperation may also help authorities respond to criminal activities that take place across different jurisdictions.

9. International Legal Frameworks

a. The Budapest Convention

The Budapest Convention has been addressing and taking action against cybercrime ever since 2001. The convention mostly consists of European states with exceptions like United States of America and Australia. The convention is the first national treaty to address cyber crime and specializes in cases of copyright infringement, computer related fraud, hate crimes on the internet, child pornography and violations of network security. The convention has been helping

nations involved exchange information and take action regarding cybercrimes ever since its establishment and is to this day a crucial framework in the fight against cybercrime. Its framework allows countries to improve cooperation when investigating crimes that cross national borders. This can be particularly useful for cases involving dark web marketplaces, where suspects, servers and financial activity may be located in different countries.

b. The 2024 United Nations Convention against Cybercrime

The 2024 United Nations Convention against Cybercrime serves a great purpose as it was a significant step in the right direction. This convention directly acknowledges and encourages international cooperation on cybercrime which includes anonymity tools and even though this convention is still fairly new it still is really important in the fight against the dark web drug trade. The convention can provide a broader international framework for countries that are not part of existing regional agreements. Its implementation could strengthen information sharing and cooperation between states when dealing with cybercrime that crosses borders.

c. International Policing Bodies

Operations against the dark web drug trade, especially the ones with a larger scale often work in cooperation with international organizations such as Interpol or Europol. Operations such as Operation DisrupTor, Operation RapTor and the more recent takedown of Archetype Market have relied heavily on cooperation facilitated by these bodies. Teaming up with large scale international bodies have many advantages ranging from improved funding to faster and more reliable global communication. These organizations can also help coordinate investigations involving multiple national law enforcement agencies. Their role becomes increasingly important as dark web criminal networks operate across several jurisdictions and can quickly move between different platforms.

10. Questions to Be Answered

1. How can member states provide and preserve privacy rights while also enabling law enforcement to access encrypted or anonymized communications and transactions?
2. How can cybercrime investigation resources and digital forensics capabilities be improved to catch up with the adaptability of drug markets and encryption technologies?
3. What actions can be taken in order to keep the youth away from dangers of the online drug trade?
4. How should law enforcement respond to the emergence of new markets after one is taken down?
5. What long term strategies can be adopted to break the pattern of new markets emerging and users relocating after a marketplace is taken down?
6. How can postal and customs authorities improve the detection of illicit drug shipments?
7. What steps can be taken to strengthen global cooperation and communication regarding cases of dark web drug trade?

8. What long term strategies can address and resolve the root causes of online drug trafficking?
9. What long term strategies can be adopted in order to make sure that emerging technologies will not be misused with malicious intentions?
10. What measures could be taken in order to regulate the misuse of cryptocurrencies without restraining legitimate financial transactions?
11. How can developing technologies like artificial intelligence be reasonably and responsibly utilized by law enforcement against the dark web drug trade?
12. How can encrypted messaging apps prevent their misuse by criminal organizations?
13. How can member states discourage the normalization and promotion of drugs on the internet?
14. Should access to anonymization tools such as Tor be restricted and or be regulated and if so to what extent?

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